Kochemasov who divulged in a 1992 Der Spiegel interview, that Werner Krolikowski, First Deputy Chairman of the GDR Ministerial Council, had confided that conditions in the Politburo were ‘unbearable’, and policy was driven by dogma. Discussion and debate, he said, ‘had been phased out’, and an ‘utterly implausible’ communications strategy was introduced. The feeling, he claimed, was that something must be done: the leader must be replaced.10

However, in the upshot, nothing happened. Interestingly, though, the affair sheds light on an attempt to discredit Honecker by Willi Stoph the previous year. After growing impatience with the SED leader’s dalliances with Western personalities, Stoph’s mind apparently oscillated from day to day between the two poles of uncertainty: Honecker’s romance with the West, which could lead to something like a reunification; and Gorbachev’s warming relationship with the USA, which could also ease relations with the FRG. Ever suspicious, it is likely the SED leader knew about Stoph’s secret note to Gorbachev in early 1986 detailing Honecker’s hostility to Soviet reforms and shoddy economic management. No doubt Stoph had hoped and expected to be rewarded, but Gorbachev never wrote back – an indication that (at that point, at least) he had no desire to support dissent. (But it is possible he knew that if Stoph did mount a successful coup, he would not encourage reforms thereafter. As it was, Stoph became hesitant and indecisive, unwilling to act against Honecker without Soviet backing.)

It is worth noting that Politburo members Heinz Hoffmann, Alfred Neumann, Erich Mielke and the SED’s chief ideologue, Kurt Hager, were also unclear about what exactly Honecker was trying to achieve with his foreign dalliances. They were equally weary of a Gorbachev–Reagan summit in Geneva where both leaders committed to an even military balance. In fact, during an interview with the West German news magazine Stern, Kurt Hager further distanced the GDR from Gorbachev’s policies with a rhetorical question: ‘Would you feel obliged to put up new wallpaper in your apartment if your neighbour were to wallpaper his?’ The statement left few people in any doubt that Gorbachev’s reform policy was not a model for the GDR.